Letter from the Executive Board

Dear Delegates,

This particular guide does not seek to provide you with information that will help you in substantively dealing with the set agenda; but simply provide you with a fair amount of context so as to ensure that you have a fair foundation on which to build your case.

The primary aspect that each and every one of you must keep in mind as you research prior to the conference, and then finally debate is the timeline in which the committee is set. It is of extreme importance that you understand that we begin our session on the **7th of August of 1964;** and this should reflect not only in the documents you use to make your arguments but also in your comprehension of issues, individuals and ideologies. The early 1960's was an immensely important period in the world's and America's modern history, and it is essential for good debate to happen in the committee that you understand and appreciate the complexities of the political situation.

Another area where I expect a basic level of understanding is the American system; in terms of how decision making works in the United State of America. I have consciously not included material about the position of the House of Representatives in the American System, as set in the Constitution of the United States in the background guide for a very simple reason, **that as individuals representing Congressmen,** you must have this information. It is incredibly easy to find, and also of supreme importance because originally when the Gulf of Tonkin resolution was discussed, **arguments about it clashing with the American System and constitution were made;** for you to talk about these issues, you must first comprehend them.

I hope you understand the significance of the **Gulf of Tonkin** resolution, not merely in terms of what direct events it led to, but in terms of the precedent it set and how it changed the world. You are armed with hindsight, because you already know what happened after the resolution was unanimously passed by the Congress in 1964; and it is this hindsight you must employ as you debate and deliberate upon what is best for America, and the world. Do you seek to reject the resolution, or amend it, or maybe you seek to ensure that it passes, just like it did originally?

I bid you luck with your research, and hope that we have a tremendous time in the three days of debate we have. Please treat this conference as an event you can take something back from and prepare adequately for it. In furtherance of ensuring a minimal level of research from all participants, I request all of you to submit a **Letter to the Speaker, in which you provide a brief description of the situation of American forces in Vietnam, *the immediate event which* led to the President demanding a resolution like the Gulf of Tonkin one from the houses; alongside your analysis of what must be done.** The word limit for this will be a 2000 words, and any participant who does not submit this document will not be eligible for a prize.

Regards,
Sameer Thakur

Text of the proposed Gulf of Tonkin Resolution

The house, when it meets on the 7th of August, 1964 will discuss the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution, drafted after the request made by the President to the Congress, which has also been provided to you. It is recommended that you are

well versed with both of them. The original document[1] is available here, but the text has been reproduced within the guide itself :

Joint Resolution

To promote the maintenance of international peace and security in southeast Asia.

Whereas naval units of the Communist regime in Vietnam, in violation of the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and of international law, have deliberately and repeatedly attacked United States naval vessels lawfully present in international waters, and have thereby created a serious threat to international peace; and

Whereas these attackers are part of deliberate and systematic campaign of aggression that the Communist regime in North Vietnam has been waging against its neighbours and the nations joined with them in the collective defence of their freedom; and

Whereas the United States is assisting the peoples of southeast Asia to protest their freedom and has no territorial, military or political ambitions in that area, but desires only that these people should be left in peace to work out their destinies in their own way: Now, therefore be it

Resolved by the Senate and House of Representatives of the United States of America in Congress assembled,

That the Congress approves and supports the determination of the President, as Commander in Chief, to take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack against the forces of the United States and to prevent further aggression.

Section 2. The United States regards as vital to its national interest and to world peace the maintenance of international peace and security in southeast Asia. Consonant with the Constitution of the United States and the Charter of the United Nations and in accordance with its obligations under the Southeast Asia Collective Defence Treaty, the United States is, therefore, prepared, as the President determines, to take all necessary steps, including the use of armed force, to assist any member or protocol state of the Southeast Asia Collective Defence Treaty requesting assistance in defence of its freedom.

Section 3. This resolution shall expire when the President shall determine that the peace and security of the area is reasonably assured by international conditions created by action of the United Nations or otherwise, except that it may be terminated earlier by concurrent resolution of the Congress.

Background

The majority of the content you will find about the **Gulf of Tonkin Incident,** will be tainted with new evidence that emerged after this session of Congress was held; all such information must be disregarded, because it was not available on the 7th of August 1964, and as such is irrelevant. However, you should keep in mind what happened because of the Vietnam war, and during it after this resolution was passed to understand if you want the war to continue or stop. You must also not limit yourself to this immediate incident even though you must focus on it, because it is integral for you to understand that in the 1960's, the Cold War was at its peak, and theories like the

[1] https://www.fold3.com/image/4346698/

domino theory had just been elucidated. You must understand the environment in America, and the rest of the western bloc for you to debate this agenda.

I have provided below, multiple links that will serve as introduction to the Cold War, the political situation America, and the Vietnam war. Please do not let these limit you, this is the minimum amount of information all of you should have, not the maximum. None of these can be cited in debate unless they are **government or media reports that were published prior to 7th of August 1964**, and are merely to provide you with information

The Gulf of Tonkin Incident

1. http://www.history.com/news/the-gulf-of-tonkin-incident-50-years-ago
2. http://edsitement.neh.gov/lesson-plan/gulf-tonkin-resolution-and-escalation-vietnam-war#sect-background
3. http://nsarchive.gwu.edu/NSAEBB/NSAEBB132/essay.htm
4. http://www.historynet.com/case-closed-the-gulf-of-tonkin-incident.htm

Timelines for US Involvement in Vietnam

1. http://www.pbs.org/battlefieldvietnam/timeline/
2. http://www.english.illinois.edu/maps/vietnam/timeline.htm

The Cold War

1. http://alphahistory.com/coldwar/domino-theory/
2. http://www.history.com/this-day-in-history/eisenhower-gives-famous-domino-theory-speech
3. http://www.globalsecurity.org/military/ops/vietnam2-domino-theory.htm
4. http://www.history.com/topics/cold-war/domino-theory
5. http://www.coldwar.org/articles/50s/vietnam_conflict.asp
6. https://www.khanacademy.org/humanities/history/euro-hist/cold-war/v/vietnam-war

American Politics and The War

1. https://www.foreignaffairs.com/articles/vietnam/1972-04-01/essential-domino-american-politics-and-vietnam
2. https://www.h-net.org/reviews/showrev.php?id=12872

Note

As you research, and then debate during the conference please keep in mind three essentials:

1. That your biggest priority is what is best for America, not the world. Understand that you are representing elected legislators in the Congress of the United States of America, the greater good is of course a concern, but the biggest motivation for you is to ensure the best for America.
2. Please ensure that you are well versed with the ideology of the political party you are from, though you are obviously free to disagree with representatives from your party, and even vote against them as Congressmen and women do quite regularly in America; yet you are expected to justify why you disagree with the view of the party on a particular issue.
3. Please remember the context. You are legislators elected in the Cold War era, the American public as well as the administration were affected by the fears caused by various ideologies during the cold war, that is, you

cannot disregard the Cold War because you think it was useless and caused problems, embrace the reality of the 1960’s.